



THE IRON CURTAIN IS SWEEPED ASIDE

THE FALL OF THE BERLIN WALL (1989)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Collapse of communism

BEFORE

August 1989 After 45 years, Poland sees the end of communist rule. Solidarity, a trade union, forms a new non-communist government.

August 23, 1989 Two million people form a human chain across Estonia, Lithuania, and Latvia in protest at Soviet rule.

September 11, 1989 Hungary opens its border with Austria to allow the departure of East German refugees.

AFTER

December 3, 1989 The US and USSR jointly declare that the Cold War has ended.

October 3, 1990 Germany is reunified.

December 1991 The Soviet Union disintegrates into 15 separate states.

For decades, the Berlin Wall, which separated East and West Berlin, stood as a reminder of the Cold War, the bitter division between Soviet communism and Western capitalism. On November 9, 1989, the East German government lifted travel restrictions, and thousands of people began converging at

the wall. East German border guards yielded in the face of ecstatic crowds. On November 10, in extraordinary scenes, soldiers from both sides helped Berliners break through the wall. Over the next two days, more than 3 million people crossed the border.

Ruling the Eastern Bloc

At the end of World War II, the USSR had banned anti-communist parties in every Eastern European country, and created a bloc of satellite states under Soviet leadership, ruthlessly suppressing any opposition. In the fall of 1956, Hungary rose against its communist government, only to be crushed by Soviet tanks, and in 1968, the USSR invaded Czechoslovakia to remove a government it found too liberal.

In the 1960s, Germany was still divided between East and West, and its former capital Berlin split into the Allied-operated West and the Soviet-controlled East. Each had its own German administration: democratic in the West, communist in the East. Thousands of East Germans escaped to the West, and the country hemorrhaged its skilled workers. On August 13, 1961, the government sealed off East from West Berlin with a fence, which, over time, became a heavily fortified barrier dividing the city, the nation, and family and friends.

In 1985, Mikhail Gorbachev was appointed as General Secretary of the Soviet Communist Party. Aiming for warmer relations with the West, he set out new reforms: *glasnost* (political "openness") and *perestroika* (liberal